

BEST IN SHOWS

Storefront shows at Court Theatre reign in our top 10.



MICHAEL BROSILOW



AARON REESE BOSEMAN



MICHAEL BROSILOW

LIFE+TRAVEL

Saveur charmante

An agro-tourism route in the Charlevoix region of Quebec offers hyperlocal bounty.

REAL ESTATE

Trapped by low rates

Some homeowners are caught between stability and a desire for change.

WINNER OF 28 PULITZER PRIZES FOR EXCELLENCE IN JOURNALISM

Final

Chicago Tribune



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SUNDAY, DECEMBER 14, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



‘THEY DESERVE TO KNOW SOMEBODY CARES’

Illinois mom covers 250 miles to reunite formerly detained immigrants with their Chicago families



Above: Natalia Cruz, 5, hugs her dad, Manny Cruz, during a welcome-home party at the Cruz home in Elgin on Dec. 4. Volunteer Rebecca De La Luz helped transport Cruz home from the North Lake Processing Center in Baldwin, Michigan.

At top: Rebecca De La Luz reaches into the back of her car to gather snacks, fruit and drinks to hand out to people visiting their loved ones detained at the North Lake Processing Center on Nov. 24 in Baldwin, Michigan. De La Luz frequently visits detainees in the Center and helps them and their families address problems. STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS

By Rebecca Johnson
Chicago Tribune

It’s pitch-black and frigid in the parking lot of an Italian restaurant in Michigan City, Indiana, by the time a small group of volunteers and immigrants gather in a circle, arms resting on each other’s shoulders and heads bent in prayer.

A pastor tells three Chicago-area men, who just hours ago had been released from an ICE detention center in Michigan, that God loves them. That any mistreatment they may have experienced didn’t escape his attention. That God will walk with them on the rest of their journey.

It’s a message that Rebecca De La Luz, one of the intrepid volunteers who wears a blue T-shirt that says “madre all day every day,” feels deeply as she nodded along that early December day. She’ll soon drive the men hours back to the city and suburbs for emotional reunions with their families, the next conductor in what the group wryly referred to as the “above-ground railroad.”

“Everything that’s happening, I want to be proactive and do something because I know in my heart that it’s not right, and these people aren’t crim-

Turn to De La Luz, Page 12

Election board’s links to Harmon

2 Dems who blocked fines have ties to Senate president’s donors

By Rick Pearson
Chicago Tribune

Two Democratic members of the Illinois State Board of Elections who helped block nearly \$10 million in campaign fines against Democratic Senate President Don Harmon have political ties to organizations that contributed disputed, above-limit donations to Harmon and continued giving to him even as the case was pending before the board.

Vice Chair Rick Terven Sr., appointed in 2021, and board member Tonya Genovese, appointed in 2022, joined their two Democratic colleagues in October and November in rejecting penalties recommended by the board’s staff and an independent hearing officer against Harmon’s Friends of Don Harmon for State Senate campaign committee.

The board staff concluded Harmon violated state campaign law by collecting \$4 million in unlimited contributions after fundraising caps he took steps to lift were reinstated, and they recommended Harmon’s campaign committee be fined \$9.8 million. The action followed a Tribune inquiry to board officials about Harmon’s fundraising practices.

A hearing examiner later rejected Harmon’s appeal. Still, the financial penalty was not imposed because the eight-member state panel repeatedly deadlocked 4-4 along party lines, short of the five votes required for final action. On Nov. 18, the board voted 5-3 to strike the matter from its docket. A separate complaint filed by the Liberty Justice Center, a libertarian-leaning group that frequently advocates for Republican causes, remains pending and could bring the matter to court.

At the center of the dispute is a loophole in Illinois campaign finance law that Harmon helped author.

Although Illinois law generally limits how much money politicians can raise from campaign contributors, the loophole allows

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INSIDE



Top photos of 2025

The Tribune photo staff covered an extraordinary year defined by joy, sadness and turmoil. Take a look at the best photos of the year. **Special section inside subscribers’ copies**

EVERYTHING’S ON THE LINE: Bears need to be able to lean into offense more with four games to go in playoff push. **Chicago Sports**

Berwyn shooting lays bare risks of broken system

Records: Husband who killed assistant principal had firearm license revoked by the state police

By Tess Kenny
Chicago Tribune

Shana Everage was in bed when she heard the back door of her Broadview home open in the early morning hours of Sept. 16. She didn’t know it at that moment, but it was her older sister Nerissa, who lived just up the street, letting herself in.

Shana got up to use the bathroom wondering what the noise was. That’s when she saw Nerissa in the room where they used to sleep when they were little. She was sitting on the bed with her head in her hands, their mom Joycelyn in the room with her.

That was the last night the

three of them spent together.

Three months ago, Nerissa Lee and Joycelyn Everage were fatally shot outside of the Berwyn middle school where Nerissa worked as an assistant principal. They were killed, police say, by Nerissa’s husband, Steven Lee, who then turned the gun on himself. Berwyn police have since closed their investigation into the shooting, deeming their deaths “domestic-related” and Steven the sole offender.

“When I wake up each morning,” Shana said, “I wake up to that reality.”

Tensions had been building for

Turn to Berwyn, Page 4



Shana Everage, sister of Assistant Principal Nerissa Lee, who was shot and killed by her husband, Steven, in September outside the Berwyn middle school where she worked. Nerissa and Shana’s mother, Joycelyn Everage, was also shot and killed by Steven Lee, who killed himself. E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE